

THE GERUND

A Complete Guide to Gerund Usage in English

As Subject

Warnings

After
Prepositions

look forward to

Possessives

Mind

No use / Worth

Fun · Trouble ·
Difficulty

Spend · Waste

Go & Come

Be Busy

Perception
Verbs

Gerund as Subject of a Sentence

When a gerund is the SUBJECT, always use a SINGULAR verb form.

Reading French is easier than speaking it.

Seeing is believing.

Dieting keeps a person from getting fat.

Walking is good exercise.

Skiing started as a modern sport in India at the same time as it did in Europe.

Swimming every morning keeps you healthy and energised.

Gerund in Warnings & Signs

Gerund used in SHORT warnings (no complement):

No smoking.

No fishing.

No waiting.

No parking.

No trespassing.

WITH complement → use SIMPLE PRESENT (imperative):

Do not touch these wires.

Do not feed the lions.

Do not enter the building.

Do not disturb.

Do not lean out of the window.

Gerund after Prepositions (Part 1)

When a verb is followed by a PREPOSITION, always use GERUND (V-ing) — not the infinitive.

I am against saying anything.

I am tired of arguing.

This is a tool for opening tins.

Do you feel like going out?

*What about leaving it here
and collecting it later?*

I am for saying nothing.

I am fed up with waiting.

After swimming I felt cold.

She disapproves of jogging.

He is thinking of emigrating.

Gerund after Prepositions (Part 2)

*I am sorry **for** keeping you waiting.*

*You should be ashamed **of** yourself for behaving so badly.*

*Aren't you interested **in** making money?*

*She succeeded **in** passing the exam despite the difficulties.*

*They escaped **by** sliding down the rope.*

***In spite of** starting late, he arrived in time.*

*There is no point **in** waiting.*

*He gave **up** smoking after years of trying.*

⚠ Exception: These are NOT Gerunds!

After these fixed expressions, use the BASE VERB (NOT gerund):

be to

have to

ought to

used to

be going to

✗ WRONG

✗ *We are to starting immediately.*

✗ *We will have to keeping detailed records.*

✗ *He ought to being home by seven.*

✗ *He used to being a doctor.*

✗ *I am not going to mending his shirt.*

✓ CORRECT

✓ *We are to start immediately.*

✓ *We will have to keep detailed records.*

✓ *He ought to be home by seven o'clock.*

✓ *He used to be a doctor.*

✓ *I am not going to mend his shirt for him.*

'to' as a Preposition → Use Gerund! (Part 1)

In these expressions 'to' is a PREPOSITION (not part of infinitive) → always followed by GERUND (V-ing).

look forward to

= expect /
anticipate

- › *I am looking forward to meeting her.*
- › *We are looking forward to hearing from you.*
- › *She is looking forward to starting her new job.*

take to

= start doing
habitually

- › *He took to ringing us up in the middle of the night.*
- › *She took to exercising every morning.*
- › *The child took to reading very quickly.*

'to' as a Preposition → Use Gerund! (Part 2)

be / become / get + used to / accustomed to = be familiar with → always followed by GERUND (V-ing).

be / get used to / accustomed to

= be familiar with

- › *She was not used to speaking Uzbek.*
- › *I am used to standing in queues.*
- › *Melanie is not accustomed to living with Sarah yet.*
- › *He got used to waking up early for work.*
- › *I am becoming accustomed to the cold weather here.*

⚠ Compare: used to + BASE VERB = past habit | be used to + GERUND = familiar with (now)

Possessive / Object Pronoun + Gerund

These verbs can take a possessive adjective OR object pronoun before the gerund.

dislike

propose

understand

dread

recollect

approve

disapprove of

fancy

remember

insist on

involve

resent

look forward to

like (negative)

save

mean

stop

mind

suggest

STRUCTURE: V + possessive adjective (my/his/her) OR object pronoun (me/him/her) + gerund

Possessive / Object Pronoun + Gerund — Examples

Tom insisted on reading the letter.

Tom insisted on my / me reading the letter.

He disliked working late.

He disliked my / me working late.

I object to paying twice for the same thing.

I object to his / him making private calls on this phone.

We are looking forward to their announcing the results.

He resented my being promoted before him.

Left = WITHOUT pronoun (subject = speaker/main subject) → Right = WITH pronoun (different subject)

excuse · forgive · pardon · prevent — Special Rules

After these verbs a PRONOUN or ADJECTIVE must come between the verb and the gerund.

FORGIVE

- › *Forgive me / my ringing up so early.*
- › *Forgive me for ringing up so early.*

PARDON

- › *Pardon me / my interrupting, but there is a client to see you.*
- › *Pardon me for interrupting, but there is a client to see you.*

PREVENT

- › *You can't prevent his / him spending his own money.*
- › *You can't prevent him from spending his own money.*

EXCUSE

- › *Please excuse my being late to the meeting.*
- › *Excuse me for not answering your call earlier.*

MIND + Gerund

MIND is used with gerund mainly in **QUESTIONS** and **NEGATIVE** sentences.

Would you mind waiting a moment?

I don't mind him / his living here.

He didn't mind Ann / Ann's leaving home.

I don't mind the noise.

I don't mind walking. (= I don't object to walking.)

He didn't mind leaving home.

Do you mind me / my smoking?

MIND — Polite Requests

Would you mind + (poss. pronoun / object pronoun) + V-ing

(MORE polite and MORE common)

- › *Would you mind my borrowing your book?*
- › *Would you mind my moving your car?*

Do you mind + (poss. pronoun / object pronoun) + V-ing

(slightly less formal)

- › *Do you mind turning down the volume a little?*
- › *Do you mind me turning down the volume a little?*

Would you mind + if + S + past simple

(asking for permission — very polite)

- › *Would you mind if I borrowed your book?*
- › *Would you mind if I moved your car?*

Do you mind + if + S + present simple

(asking for permission — neutral)

- › *Do you mind if I turn down the volume a little?*
- › *Do you mind if I use your phone?*

'No Use' & 'No Good' Expressions

When there is NO NEED or NO BENEFIT in doing an action, use these structures with GERUND.

There is no use + gerund

There is no use arguing any more.

It is no good complaining — nothing will change.

It is no use pretending you don't know.

It is no use + gerund

It is no use trying — no one ever gets out of here.

There is no use crying over spilled milk.

It is no good waiting for him — he never comes on time.

It is no good + gerund

Be Worth + Gerund

WORTH + gerund means: doing the action is BENEFICIAL or VALUABLE.

be + worth + gerund

There is nothing worth reading in this newspaper.

Do you think it is worth remembering that date?

It is not worth arguing about such a small matter.

The film is definitely worth watching.

If you are a young driver, it is worth having comprehensive insurance.

*This book is worth reading — every chapter is fascinating.
The museum is worth visiting if you are interested in history.*

Learning a new language is always worth the effort.

have / be + fun · problem · trouble · difficulty + Gerund

These expressions describe a person's EXPERIENCE or DIFFICULTY with an activity.

fun

a good
time

problem

trouble

difficulty

a hard time

a difficult
time

It is no fun having to work on Sundays.

Parents often have trouble finding restaurants that welcome young children.

We didn't have any problem finding the house.

I am having a difficult time understanding the instructions.

We had a good time playing football with them.

She had great difficulty finding a job after graduation.

He had a hard time accepting the bad news.

They had a good time dancing at the party.

spend · waste + time / money + Gerund

spend + time / money + gerund

- › *He spends two hours a day travelling.*
- › *He doesn't spend much time preparing his lessons.*

waste + time / money + gerund

- › *He has wasted his time doing unnecessary things.*
- › *Don't waste your time watching TV all day.*

it is a waste of + time / money + gerund

- › *It is a waste of her talents dealing with such filthy things.*
- › *It is a waste of time chatting all the time.*

go & come + Gerund (Physical Activities & Shopping)

go / come + gerund → used with PHYSICAL ACTIVITIES and SHOPPING words.

bird watching

hiking

sightseeing

boating

hunting

skating

bowling

jogging

skiing

camping

mountain
climbing

sledding

canoeing

running

swimming

dancing

sailing

tobogganing

fishing

shopping

window-
shopping

We went out at sunrise to go bird watching.

They used to go camping in Spain when they were young.

Will you come sledding with us?

We decided to go boating on the lake.

We could go tobogganing on Primrose Hill.

He goes jogging for half an hour before breakfast.

Be Busy + Gerund

be busy + gerund → describes someone who is OCCUPIED doing something at that moment.

be busy + V-ing

She is busy writing out the wedding invitations.

She was / is busy packing her suitcase for the trip.

The manager was busy interviewing candidates all morning.

We were so busy cooking dinner that we forgot to call.

He was too busy talking to notice us come in.

They were busy preparing the annual report.

He is busy fixing the car in the garage.

The children are busy making decorations for the party.

Perception Verbs + Gerund vs. Bare Infinitive

Perception verbs (see, hear, feel, watch, notice) take GERUND (ongoing) or BARE INFINITIVE (complete action).

V + sb/sth + GERUND (ongoing — action in progress)

I saw him changing the wheel.

(He was in the middle of changing.)

Tom heard her singing.

(She was singing when he heard her.)

I felt the car skidding.

I saw smoke rising from the chimney.

From the window we could see the children playing.

V + sb/sth + BARE INFINITIVE (complete — whole action seen)

I saw him change the wheel.

(I saw the whole action from start to end.)

Tom heard her sing.

(He heard the whole performance.)

We saw him leave the house.

I heard him make arrangements for his journey.

Joe saw Mary enter, unlock a drawer, photograph it and put it back.

Quick Reference Summary

1 As Subject

Singular verb
Reading is fun. / Seeing is believing.

2 Warnings

No + gerund (no complement)
Do not + V (with complement)

3 After Prepositions

Always gerund after prep.
I'm tired OF arguing.

4 look forward / take to / used to

'to' = preposition here
→ gerund
I look forward to MEETING.

5 Possessive + Gerund

dislike / mind / insist on +
my / me + V-ing

6 excuse / prevent

Must have pronoun between verb and gerund.

7 MIND

Would you mind waiting?
Do you mind if I open the window?

8 No use / No good

It is no use arguing.
There is no point in waiting.

9 Worth

It is worth reading.
worth + gerund = beneficial

10 spend / waste

spend time travelling
waste time arguing

11 go / come +

go camping / swimming / skiing
come sledding / jogging

12 Perception Verbs

saw him CHANGING = in progress
saw him CHANGE = complete

Keep Practising!

The gerund is everywhere in natural English — master it and your writing will feel truly fluent.

✓ After prepositions → ALWAYS gerund (tired of waiting, interested in making)

✓ look forward to / used to / take to → 'to' is a preposition → gerund follows

✓ MIND → questions & negatives | Would you mind / Do you mind + V-ing

✓ spend / waste + time/money + gerund | go / come + activity gerund

✓ Perception verbs: GERUND = in progress · BARE INFINITIVE = complete action